

The rock cycle

As soon as igneous rocks are exposed to the air, they start to be eroded, creating sediments. These often form sedimentary rock, which may then be buried and transformed into metamorphic rock. If this is drawn below the crust, it may melt and erupt as lava that undergoes the whole process over again. This is known as the rock cycle.

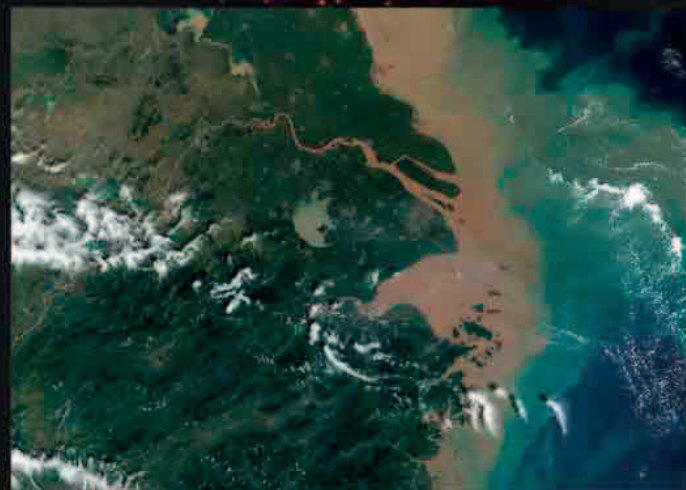
▼ **FIRE FOUNTAIN**
Blown into the air by gas pressure, this fountain of lava will cool to form igneous rock.

ERUPTION

Igneous rock is created when volcanic lava erupts and cools on the surface, or when molten magma pushes up between existing rocks and cools underground. Lava is attacked by the weather right away and starts crumbling. Buried intrusions of rocks such as granite must be exposed to the air before they start to break down.

EROSION

As soon as rock is erupted or exposed on the surface of the land, it begins to fall apart. It is dissolved, split, crumbled, and eroded by rain, ice, sunshine, windblown sand, flowing water, and plant roots. The rocky debris, sand, and dissolved minerals are carried away by glaciers, rivers, or the wind.



▲ **SWEPT AWAY**
Fine sediment eroded from the plains of China is swept out to sea by the Yangtze River.